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The pale fox

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Thus transformed and deprived of a part of his spiritual principles, the Fox, who will feed primarily on insects, burrowed into the cracks of caves, like he did into his placenta: one says that his earth, or lair, measures twelve cubits deep, this number being symbolic of the twelve months of the year and of the "number" attributed to the rebel.

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Since that time, it is as if the Fox were in exile, in a separate world; this exile is due to his impurity. Alone, incomplete, and ever rebellious, but active, he will play a necessary part in the development of life on Earth. For it is said that Amma provoked Ogo's actions in order to experiment with the universe in formation: "Amma made the Fox do all these things to try him out in the world." ⁷⁷ Therefore, one sometimes adds that Amma, angry at Ogo's reascent, reproached him for this unauthorized act and forced him to go down again, "to show the way" for all the future "descents" of the beings created in his womb.

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The Fox had initiated agriculture, but by sowing stolen seeds — the "semen" of his "father" Amma — inside the Earth, his "mother." It will be necessary to purify the soil, parched by incest, in order to renew its fertility. To carry out this purification, men will sow in their turn, but with seeds given to them by Amma for this purpose, and not with stolen ones. The Fox will then leave to take refuge in the uncultivated bush, his domain. However, man will follow him and will again purify new territory by delimiting new fields. Thus, the Fox's presence as well as his actions will promote the expansion of mankind.

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This idea of the expansion of the human domain, progressively impinging upon that of the Fox (who show the way), is illustrated or inaugurated (one may say) in children's games. The role of the very young children, who have a "joking relationship" with the Fox (*manu*), is to play  290 with his "earth," ⁷⁸ both to look for him and to chase him away. To model animals or objects out of earth is to imitate the Fox who "scratched" to tear away his placenta. The game *sey*, played by two children with a small pebble or a small *bey* seed (bean), hidden in a handful of dirt, consists in pushing the partner back into his own territory until he has been driven out of a circle traced on the ground: this is the Nommo pursuing the Fox. ⁷⁹

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77. *amma yurugumon kize ua kanu fu aduno sone uoy suburu yenede kay.*

78. "The work of the little children is to play with the earth," *unu uzi bire minne-ne yogoro yogori.*

79. For a complete description of this game, cf. M. Griaule, *Jeux Dogons*, p. 172.

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